Soon after, Nur Mohammad Taraki became the first Khalqi PM of Afghanistan with support from his inner circle, or the 'Gang of Four'—Sarwari, Mohammad Aslam Watanjar, Sherjan Mazdooryar, Sayed Mohammad Gulabzoi (see prologue)—and the Soviet Union. Hafizullah Amin, another ambitious Khalqi who was at odds with Taraki and his confidants, became the deputy PM and foreign minister. Though Leonid Brezhnev, the then general secretary of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union (CPSU), denied any Soviet role in the events leading up to the revolution, the PDPA's bloody rise had shorn Afghanistan of its non-alignment rhetoric completely. The Soviet Union became the first country to recognise the new Kabul government. On 5 December 1978, much like what India did in 1971, Afghanistan signed a treaty of friendship with Moscow, which allowed Moscow to develop a robust civilian and military presence in the country.[85] Afghanistan was firmly in the Soviet orbit, and was soon recognised by New Delhi.

India's decision to recognise the PDPA regime (or the Democratic Republic of Afghanistan, DRA) in 1978 was influenced by New Delhi's dependence on the Soviet Union on one hand and aversion to rising Islamist radicalism in Pakistan, Afghanistan, and Iran, on the other (and not just its rivalry with Pakistan). In 1977, Bhutto had been ousted (and later assassinated) in a coup by Pakistan's army chief Zia-ul-Haq, who had strong Islamist inclinations. Accepting the new 'secular' regime in Kabul was a way for India's Janata Party government, which had promised 'genuine non-alignment' as a foreign policy goal, to signal to Moscow that it had not strayed off from Nehru's regional policy framework.[86] Though Indian diplomats, by August 1978, started pressing their American counterparts to diversify Afghanistan's source of developmental funding to wean off Kabul from becoming completely dependent on the Soviets (a view shared by the Americans), Moscow continued to play a preponderant strategic role in the region.[87] Then EAM Atal Bihari Vajpayee undertook his second visit to Kabul in September 1978 (the previous one having been in September 1977 soon after the change of government in India) and iterated continuity in India's friendship with Afghanistan. Offering assistance to Kabul in 'any manner' Afghanistan chose, Vajpayee articulated the consensus in India for friendly ties with Afghanistan regardless of political change in either country.[88]